

home. Yet once they get involved in economics, they all prefer professionally to use in Extremistan the measures made for Mediocristan, on the ground that “we have nothing else.” The idea, well accepted by grandmothers, that one should pick a destination for which one has a good map, not travel and then find “the best” map, is foreign to PhDs in social science.

3) Thinking that a Black Swan should be a Black Swan to all observers. (Mistake made by people who have not spent a lot of time in Brooklyn and lack the street smarts and social intelligence to realize that *some* people are suckers.)

4) Not understanding the value of negative advice (“Don’t do”) and writing to me to ask me for something “constructive” or a “next step.” (Mistake usually made by chairmen of large companies and those who would like someday to become such chairmen.)[‡]

5) Not understanding that doing nothing can be much more preferable to doing something potentially harmful. (Mistake made by most people who are not grandmothers.)

6) Applying to my ideas labels (*skepticism, fat tails, power laws*) off a supermarket shelf and equating those ideas with inadequate research traditions (or, worse, claiming it was dealt with by “modal logic,” “fuzzy logic,” or whatever the person has vaguely heard of). (Mistake made by those with graduate degrees from both coasts.)

7) Thinking that *The Black Swan* is about the errors of using the bell curve, which supposedly everyone knew about, and that the errors can be remedied by substituting a number from the Mandelbrotian in place of another. (Mistake made by the pseudoscientific brand of tenured finance professors, like, say, Kenneth French.)

8) Claiming that “we knew all this” and “there is nothing new” in my idea during 2008, then, of course, going bust during the crisis. (Mistake made by the same type of tenured finance professors as before, but these went to work on Wall Street, and are now broke.)

9) Mistaking my idea for Popper’s notion of falsification—or taking any of my ideas and fitting them in a prepackaged category that sounds familiar. (Mistakes mostly made by sociologists, Columbia University political science professors, and others trying to be multidisciplinary intellectuals and learning buzzwords from Wikipedia.)

10) Treating probabilities (of future states) as measurable, like the temperature or your sister’s weight. (People who did a PhD at MIT or something like that, then went to work somewhere, and now spend time